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Handout: Shell-Chord Inversions on Guitar

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In this lesson, we will learn about *shell-chord inversions*: a slick compositional trick for reharmonizing your chord progressions.

Prerequisites

In theory, this is considered an *advanced technique*, but on guitar it becomes so visual and mechanical that we can “fake” knowing far deeper music theory in our songs.

All we really need is:

- a sense of octaves,
- the ability to play power chords,
- basic major and minor chord shapes.

In other words, the same fundamentals every beginner guitarist already knows.

What is a Shell Chord?

A *shell chord* is basically a stripped-down version of a chord: you keep the notes that define its harmonic identity and skip the ones that don't add much.¹

Example: For typical chord shapes with root on E string, the shell usually corresponds to keeping just the notes on the E, D, and G strings. For instance:

A7		Shell A7
e -5-	=>	e —
B -5-		B —
G -6-		G -6-
D -5-		D -5-
A -7-		A —
E -5-		E -5-

That is, we remove all the octaves and the 5th (the notes on the A and B strings), which is almost always disposable because it doesn't add much harmonically; it mostly just makes the chord “bigger” or “louder”.

¹ Jazz players often use shell chords to outline extended chords (sevenths, ninths, etc.). We will look at a typical example in a moment, but don't worry if those chords aren't familiar; we won't need them for what we're doing here.

Here's another example:

Bmin7		Shell Bmin7
e -7-	=>	e —
B -7-		B —
G -7-		G -7-
D -7-		D -7-
A -9-		A —
E -7-		E -7-

Demonstration: We will now play the chord progression A7 → Bmin7 first with the full chord shapes, then with the shell-chord versions, so you can hear how the shell chords open up the sound and make the progression feel less clunky and more flexible.

Shell-Chord Inversions in 3 Simple Steps

We will walk through the technique with a simple example. Start with any progression built from major and minor chords. For instance:

	A	C#m	D	C#m	Bm	A
e	-0—	4—	5—	4—	2—	0-
B	-2—	5—	7—	5—	3—	2-
G	-2—	6—	7—	6—	4—	2-
D	-2—	6—	7—	6—	4—	2-
A	-0—	4—	5—	4—	2—	0-
E	—————					

Step 1: Strip everything down to power chords, but play them one octave higher. This gives you only the root + 5th, which clears out all the clutter but it also removes the harmonically defining note of the chord, the 3rd.

	A5	C#5	D5	C#5	B5	A5
e	—————					
B	—————					
G	-9—	13—	14—	13—	11—	9-
D	-7—	11—	12—	11—	9—	7-
A	—————					
E	—————					

Step 2: Now add the note that turns each power chord into a *major* or *minor* chord (that is, the 3rd) but place it as the new bass note. This flips each chord into an inversion while keeping the visual simplicity of the pattern.

C#/A5 E/C#5 F#/D5 E/C#5 D/B5 C#/A5

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e | _____ |
B | _____ |
G | -9-----13-----14-----13-----11-----9- |
D | -7-----11-----12-----11-----9-----7- |
A | _____ |
E | -9-----12-----14-----12-----10-----9- |

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What's happening here is the little magic trick behind shell-chord inversions: you keep the upper structure identical (the octave-higher power chord), and you only swap the bass note to encode the major/minor quality. It sounds smooth, intentional, and far more harmonically sophisticated than the fingerwork actually is: the whole thing only takes three fingers on three strings to play.

Step 3: Now that we have a free finger and three open strings to work with, we can add embellishments by ear with almost no effort, because the core harmonic structure is already locked in. For instance:

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e | _____ | _____ - | _____ |
B | _____ | _____ | _____ |
G | -9-9----- | -13-13----- | -14-16----- |
D | -7-7----- | -11-11----- | -12-----12----- |
A | _____ | _____ | _____ |
E | -9-9-9- | -12-----12-----12- | -14-----14-----14- |

e | _____ | _____ | _____ |
B | _____ | -10----- | -9----- |
G | -13-14----- | -11-----11----- | -9-9----- |
D | -11-----11----- | -9-----9----- | -7-7----- |
A | _____ | _____ | _____ |
E | -12-----12-----12- | -10-----10----- | -9-9----- |

```

Here, I'm just arpeggiating each shell-chord inversion and sprinkling in four simple embellishment notes (shown in bold in the original notation). Those tiny additions create motion and color without changing the underlying harmony, because the shell chord is already doing the heavy lifting. This is the doorway into making your lines sound more expressive while barely increasing the technical difficulty.

Practice

Now take your own simple progression made of major and minor chords and work through the three steps yourself.